



Research Paper

Fathers' Engagement with and perceptions of child play: Evidence from the Rohingya camps of Cox's Bazar, Bangladesh[☆]

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ABSTRACT

Research on father engagement is heavily focused on Western families. Western-based programs to support fathers often do so in an individualistic manner, failing to address cultures in places where collective care is common. Limited existing research on fathers' involvement in play emphasizes the influence of income and working status on fathers' views on play. Overall, there is very little research on fathers' perceptions of play in refugee contexts, and there is no extensive study exploring this topic in the Rohingya context. In this context of forced displacement, we ask the following research question about the Rohingya fathers' perceptions of play.

Research Question:

How do fathers perceive children's play in both structured (Humanitarian Play Labs) as well as unstructured (home and surrounding areas) play settings in the Rohingya camps in Cox's Bazar, Bangladesh?

Methodology:

In this research, we employed two different approaches to data collection:

Semi-structured interviews consisted of 25 Rohingya fathers aged between 23 and 48, all of which had one child in BRAC's 0-6 early childhood age range. Interviews consisted of questions related to playing with child, discipline/behavior management, and child participation in Humanitarian Play Lab (HPL) programs.

Child Point-of-View Observations included 61 focal children and recorded 5-minute observations with the aim of recording experiences from the child's point of view, and focused on ways children socialize with other children and adults.

Findings:

Results from the study suggest that fathers spend more time with children post-forced displacement allowing them to keenly observe their children's play, their interaction with peers and play objects in the surroundings and associated behaviors, supported by observations from children's points of view. Our findings emphasize a key concern among all fathers in the study – specific to this humanitarian context – is safety and security of children at play in the camp settings. In our research, we provide a number of recommendations for fathers' active involvement in existing child development programs to enhance children's socioemotional development and socialization through play.

1. Introduction

In the densely populated refugee camps of Cox's Bazar, Bangladesh, over 900,000 Rohingya, including nearly half a million children, face the harsh realities of displacement (Population Factsheet, 2022;

Humanitarian Action for Children, 2021). Displacement is associated with heightened risk for children's socio-emotional and peer-related difficulties (Khan et al., 2018). In humanitarian settings, play has been identified as a meaningful way for children to cope with stress and rebuild a sense of safety and routine (Holst et al., 2020; Mariam et al.,

[☆] Semi-structured interview protocol and child observational tool protocol are both available from the authors.

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2019). In this study, we use “play” to refer to voluntary, enjoyable, and developmentally meaningful activities through which children explore, interact, and practice social roles, across both structured and unstructured settings. A large body of research links play to children’s socio-emotional, cognitive, and meta-cognitive development (Elias & Berk, 2002; Guirguis, 2018; Whitebread et al., 2009).

Fathers’ involvement in children’s everyday routines, including play, has been associated with multiple developmental outcomes, such as cognitive growth, early literacy, and social skills, across diverse contexts (Bocknek et al., 2017; McWayne et al., 2013; Sethna et al., 2017; Tamis-LeMonda et al., 2009; Roopnarine & Yildirim, 2019; Frongillo et al., 2017). However, most evidence on father-child play and father involvement has been generated in Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic (WEIRD) settings (Hossain, 2013; Li et al., 2021). Evidence from non-WEIRD and low- and middle-income settings suggests that fathers’ involvement is influenced by cultural norms, labor conditions, and caregiving expectations (Hossain, 2013; Ball & Khan Wahedi, 2010; Jesmin & Seward, 2011; Roopnarine & Yildirim, 2019; Frongillo et al., 2017), yet these dynamics remain underexplored in humanitarian and displacement contexts. Research on fatherhood and play in displaced and refugee communities remains limited, leaving gaps in understanding how cultural norms and displacement conditions shape fathers’ perceptions and participation in children’s play.

In the Rohingya context, this gap is especially pronounced. Research on fathers’ perceptions of play is scarce, with limited work noting fathers’ recognition that group play may benefit children (Khaled & Afsana, 2020). This lack of evidence underscores the need to examine how displacement and camp conditions may influence fathers’ roles in children’s play in both unstructured environments (home and surrounding areas) and structured early childhood spaces. Understanding fathers’ perceptions of time spent in play is critical because such perceptions shape daily caregiving practices, support for early childhood programs, and children’s access to play opportunities. Accordingly, this study examines how Rohingya fathers in Cox’s Bazar perceive their time with children, particularly regarding play, in unstructured settings and in structured Humanitarian Play Lab (HPL) settings. Our research question is: How do fathers perceive their time with children, particularly regarding play, in unstructured (home and surrounding areas) and structured (HPL) play settings in the Rohingya camps in Cox’s Bazar, Bangladesh?

2. Literature review

This section explores available literature on multifaceted concept of play in early childhood development (ECD) and humanitarian settings as well as the unique role of fathers in both Western and South Asian contexts.

2.1. Play in early childhood development

The term ‘play’ encompasses a variety of definitions and is central to ECD. In the United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (UN, 2013), play is defined as a means for children to self-protect, participate in their environment, and mitigate severe stress (Lester & Russell, 2010). Research demonstrates that play contributes to social development, emergent literacy skills, and self-regulation (Guirguis, 2018; Yogman et al., 2018) and serves as an important way for children to interact with their environments and build resilience (Lester & Russell, 2010). Researchers have categorized play in several ways, especially in WEIRD contexts. According to Yogman et al. (2018), categories of play observed in children’s development include object play, physical, locomotor/rough-and-tumble play, outdoor play, social/pretend play alone, and social/pretend play with others. Similar categories are found in subsets of play, including risky play, in which children may engage in play with great heights, high speed, dangerous materials, unsupervised exploration, or physical impact (Sandseter et al., 2021).

In addition to the categorization of types of play, existing research explores the importance of space where play occurs. Lester and Russell (2010) mention that the environment of the child influences their ability to play, and the intertwining of play and work has lessened with modernization. In some contexts, even if children do not play in school, parents are hesitant for children to play at home for fear of accidents (Ogunyemi & Henning, 2020). In a study on risky play, researchers found that more risky play was observed in outdoor environments over indoor environments during free play time (Sandseter et al., 2021), and additional research on play setting finds that children in tranquil environments (e.g. controlled science museum setting) were immersed in creative play for extended periods of time in comparison to children in an active nursery environment, where they engaged in creative play but the activities were fleeting (Arnott & Duncan, 2019). This study extends beyond Western-focused research on play by capturing children’s naturalistic play in humanitarian settings, thus enriching our understanding of the types of play they engage in, their playmates, and the objects used in play. This approach offers a more authentic and comprehensive view of early childhood development and play in humanitarian settings.

Play-Based Learning unifies play with educational pedagogy and has a wide spectrum of opportunities from child-directed to adult-directed play (Taylor & Boyer, 2020; Zosh et al., 2017). Similar to literature on play, research on play-based learning suggests that integrating play with learning can be beneficial for child development. Moreover, different cultural contexts require examining the play-learning relationship differently as societal and parental expectation around play vary from one context to another. Although limited research exists on play and play-based learning in diverse contexts, including Nigeria, South Africa, Senegal, Tunisia, Zimbabwe, and Uganda (Ogunyemi & Henning, 2020), research on parental perspectives of play in South Asian and Rohingya parenting context is almost nonexistent.

2.2. The role of play in humanitarian contexts

Play is a large part of the early childhood experience that persists even in humanitarian settings. The United Nations Convention on the Rights of the Child (2013) outlines that while these rights are given lower priority during situations of conflict or disaster than food, shelter, and medicine; opportunities for play, recreation, and cultural activity can have a significant therapeutic and rehabilitative role in helping children recover from trauma and restore a sense of identity.

Play interventions related to refugee children in Bangladesh are primarily focused on treatment of childhood trauma (Holst et al., 2020; Mariam et al., 2019). Research finds support for practices such as child-centered play therapy in the USA (Schottelkorb et al., 2012) and group play therapy in South Korea (Kwon & Lee, 2018), both of which were seen as important in alleviating psychological challenges of refugee children. Furthermore, research on playgroups in Australia discusses the importance of support for parents, since allowing refugee parents and children to have access to each other can alleviate separation anxiety and support prosocial behaviors (Jackson, 2006). Outside of refugee camps, in shared community spaces such as refugee accommodation centers in Germany, research shows that older refugee children often take advantage of play resources over younger children, especially in circumstances of over-crowdedness or limited resources (Wihstutz, 2020). There is also evidence of the role of mixed-age peer groups in children’s development in diverse cultural contexts such as Cameroon (Nsamenang, 2010), Morocco (García-Sánchez, 2016), and Mayan cultures (Gaskins, 2014) with little to no research on the nature of peer groups in refugee or humanitarian settings.

Research from WEIRD contexts defines peer groups as children with similar interests or ages (APA; Little, 2020; Wolf, 2008). In non-Western settings, such as Cameroon, Morocco, and Mayan cultures, mixed-age peer groups are common, with older children guiding younger ones to foster cooperation and leadership (Nsamenang, 2010; García-Sánchez, 2016; Gaskins, 2014). Similarly, in the Rohingya camps, fathers observe

their children forming mixed-age peer groups, where older children scaffold play for younger ones, supporting both social and cognitive development. This aligns with global findings while reflecting the unique conditions of the camps. Fathers' awareness of these peer dynamics highlights their evolving role in monitoring and understanding children's play in a resource-constrained setting. In this paper, we adopt a similar definition, defining peer groups as naturally occurring mixed-age groups of Rohingya children in Cox's Bazar camps from the fathers' perspectives. We use the term peer groups interchangeably with mixed age groups and naturally occurring peer groups.

2.3. Fathers' involvement with children and in play

The quality and amount of involvement that fathers have with their children can affect children's long-term development (Barker et al., 2017). Tamis-LeMonda et al. (2009) found that prenatal involvement of Dominican, Mexican, and African American fathers predicted engagement with children post-birth, emphasizing the role of fathers' involvement prior to birth in New York City in USA. Additional research in infancy finds that fathers' involvement correlates significantly with children's sense of security at later ages (Grossman, et al. 2002). During early childhood, fathers' responsive interactions with their children have been shown to positively influence a range of developmental outcomes across diverse contexts. These include enhanced cognitive development in the UK (Sethna et al., 2017), early literacy skills in Trinidad and Tobago (Roopnarine & Yildirim, 2019), early numeracy in 26 low- and middle-income countries (Frongillo et al., 2017), and social growth, such as improved self-regulation capacities in various settings (McWayne et al., 2013). In Australia, more father-child time is overall associated with higher levels of cognitive development, with stronger associations for father-child time that is spent on educational activities (Cano et al., 2019).

Studies on father-child play in Western contexts show that children may benefit from play with fathers at early stages. Bocknek et al. (2017) find that active playtime with fathers in the USA allows children to engage with parent-mediated processes contributing to self-regulation development. In China, research on rough-and-tumble play with toddlers shows that challenging children, while providing them with the opportunity to win, is uniquely associated with fewer toddler aggressive behaviors, even beyond controls like child gender, temperament, and authoritarian parenting attitudes (Anderson et al., 2017). Fathers' physical play, which includes rough-and-tumble play, is found to be positively associated with important child behavioral domains including social competence, emotional skills, and self-regulation in a meta-analysis focused on Western contexts (StGeorge & Freeman, 2017). Similarly, Ahnert et al. (2017), in a multi-site study in urban cities in Austria and Germany, found beneficial effects of fathers' play on reducing child internalizing behaviors. They found that fathers who reported adverse childhood experiences had lower play quality than other fathers in the sample, and the more severe the adversities, the lower the quality of play. In addition to child development, hormone research in father-child play in the Philippines has discovered that there are hormonal changes to fathers after play with their young children (Gettler, et al. 2011), displaying that father involvement in play relates to both child development and father psychobiology. Father-child play, as shown in existing research, can affect child development in a multitude of ways, but fathers can also experience positive effects of father-child play. Again, much of this research has been conducted in WEIRD contexts.

The literature around fatherhood norms in Bangladesh may inform father involvement with play in this regional context (we note that there are no studies of father involvement with the Rohingya in their pre-displacement context of Rakhine province, Myanmar). In both rural and urban areas of Bangladesh, mothers are considered the primary caregiver and spend more time in childcare and assisting children in academic work compared to fathers; this disparity in childcare responsibilities is higher amongst rural families (Hossain, 2013; Hossain &

Atencio, 2017). Social norms primarily dictate that fathers in Bangladesh have patriarchal authority over the family and are considered breadwinners and protectors of the family (Jesmin & Seward, 2011). This is further supported by research in both Bangladeshi and Rohingya contexts suggesting that fathers are key decision-makers in children's healthcare, education, and social activities, and are often the sole financial providers (Ball & Khan Wahedi, 2010; Khaled & Afsana, 2020). Additionally, considering the practice of *purdah* (Ball and Khan Wahedi, 2010), which governs how women present themselves in public spaces by limiting their physical mobility (Coyle et al., 2020), fathers are deemed responsible for tasks that occur outdoors (Jesmin & Seward, 2011; Ball & Khan Wahedi, 2010). Similar religious and regional practices provide insights into the common and accepted roles of fatherhood in Rohingya camp contexts even though there are no studies on father involvement and engagement with early childhood in the Rohingya camps in Bangladesh.

2.4. Context of the current study

The Rohingya community, one of the most persecuted minorities in the world, has been residing in Arakan – the historical name for the border region of Myanmar, now known as the East Rakhine state – for hundreds of years (Kiragu et al., 2011). Due to systematic discrimination, statelessness, and targeted violence against the people in the Rakhine State by the Myanmar army, Rohingyas had to escape their homes in several waves, fleeing to Bangladesh in 1978, between 1991–1992, and again in 2017 (Rohingya Refugee Crisis, 2019). The largest influx of Rohingyas, approximately 745,000 people including more than 400,000 children, arrived in Bangladesh in August 2017 following a massacre in Myanmar, where thousands of Rohingya were murdered. As a result of the mass exodus, many additional camps were set up in the Cox's Bazar region of Bangladesh to accommodate the Rohingya populations (Milton et al., 2017).

In response to the lack of holistic ECD services in this crisis, in 2018 and 2019, a local NGO (anonymized for peer review) launched 300 Humanitarian Play Labs or HPLs for the Rohingya children between the years of 4–6 with the slogan “Play to Heal, Play to Learn.” (BRAC IED, 2019). In 2020, they added a community home model, adding 1,400 home-based sites to this project to serve more 0–4-year-olds. The aim of HPLs is to promote and leverage Rohingya language and culture, with the values of promoting healing, learning, and ECD activities through play to address learning and developmental needs of children in humanitarian emergency situations (Mariam et al., 2019). Monitored by the NGO employees and led by play leaders, HPLs offer safe spaces for children to engage in playful activities including play-based learning, light exercises, and snacking (Sunny, 2021). The curriculum includes Rohingya *kabbiyas* (folk rhymes), *kissas* (stories with developmental and moral lessons), traditional games, physical activities, and art projects including drawing and crafting, with an emphasis on social and emotional learning among children as well as child protection, health, and hygiene (Mariam et al., 2021). The model also included group-based contact with mothers on the topics of play, childcare, and parent-child relationships (Mariam et al., 2019).

Rohingya parents shared that they were unfamiliar with preschools, early childhood programs in which children learn about play and socialization, as well as play-based learning, a concept that unifies play and educational pedagogy (Taylor & Boyer, 2020). Without any national identity or recognition in Myanmar, Rohingya families often did not have access to formal schooling and were more likely to send their children to *madrasahs* or *maktabs* (religious schools) for early education. Given the cultural context where religion plays a critical role in informing parents' choices concerning children's education, the idea of learning and healing through play is considered a foreign concept, and the integration of play in educational settings may be difficult to implement in practice, as in other Global South contexts (Ogunyemi & Henning, 2020). Considering the positive influences of play-based

learning on development, such as social development, emergent literacy skills, self-regulation (Guirguis, 2018; Yogman et al. 2018), and healing amongst children (Mariam et al., 2021), HPLs are an attempt to integrate evidence-based research on play and early childhood development into the lives of Rohingya children and parents.

In 2020 and 2021, we set out to better understand how parents engage with children and their play in the Rohingya camps in Cox's Bazar, among families who attended HPLs and those who did not. As part of this work, we inquired about how fathers engage with their children in everyday activities, and within these activities when and how play occurred and evolved.

3. Methods

Data were collected in the Rohingya refugee camps of Cox's Bazar, Bangladesh. This study employed a mixed-methods design, integrating semi-structured interviews with rapid ethnographic assessments, to examine how fathers perceive and engage with their children's play.

3.1. Participants

3.1.1. Semi-structured interviews

The sample involved 25 Rohingya fathers, aged 23 to 48, from six different camps in Cox's Bazar district. These fathers had between one to seven children, with at least one child in the age bracket of 2–4 years old. This sample is demographically reflective of the broader adult male population within the camps, characterized by high unemployment or occasional work such as volunteering or construction (World Bank, 2019). The child point-of-view observations included 61 focal children.

3.1.2. Rapid ethnographic assessment

this study included 61 children between the ages of 2 and 5 years. Of these, 41% were participants in the HPL program, while 59% were not. Non-HPL participants were identified either through the local *majhee* (community leader) or randomly, with consent from their caregivers. The focal children were observed interacting with the following groups: fathers (24–45 years), mothers (20–35 years), other adults (24–52 years), and other non-focal children (8 months–12 years).

3.2. Procedure

The methodological approach consisted of semi-structured interviews and rapid ethnographic assessment. (1) Semi-structured Interviews: Interviews were conducted in Rohingya/Chittagonian Bangla by trained enumerators from a local agency, targeting 22 fathers whose children were enrolled in the HPLs and 3 whose children were not. The semi-structured format allowed for in-depth exploration of fathers' perspectives on play. (2) Rapid Ethnographic Assessment: In this context, local Bangladeshi enumerators from Chittagong often had limited access to the camps for set periods of time. To address this, a rapid ethnographic approach was used to organically capture children's everyday experiences from their own perspectives (Bolisetty et al., 2022). Observations were conducted in eight camps within Cox's Bazar, alongside survey data collection, to avoid drawing undue attention or scrutiny to participating families. Enumerators were trained to shadow a focal child for a brief period (~5 minutes, with some variation for interruptions) and to record detailed notes on the child's activities and interactions. Additional notes were taken to describe the child's physical and social environment. Field notes were written directly in English and submitted immediately after each field visit.

3.3. Data analysis

A bilingual research team analyzed the data using a developed codebook for thematic analysis. Dedoose, a mixed-methods analysis software, was utilized for organizing and coding the interview data. We

developed a detailed coding manual to ensure consistency among coders, recognizing the subjective nature of qualitative coding. A total of 11 distinct codes emerged, and the reported themes evolved from an iterative coding process. Regular, structured discussions were held to challenge and refine coding decisions, addressing potential biases. A subset of the interview data was independently coded by two researchers to ensure intercoder reliability and consistency in theme identification. The exercise allowed us to identify and correct inconsistencies, emphasizing the need for adaptability in our methods. Our coding process was iterative, acknowledging that our initial interpretations could evolve and improve. We documented the coding process over Dedoose for transparency and to guard against bias. We actively incorporated coder feedback during weekly meetings, ensuring our methodology remained dynamic and open to scrutiny. Similarly, we used a continually updated coding manual for child observation data. One person coded all data, which was then reviewed by another for accuracy and cultural relevance.

Discussions and weekly check-ins over six months facilitated the refinement of themes and the finalization of findings. Quotes from the fathers' interviews were carefully chosen in line with the final themes, following collaborative team discussions, to enrich the thematic insights with researchers' perspectives. Field notes from child observations were similarly coded, utilizing an iterative coding process in Dedoose. Findings from the rapid ethnography were cross-referenced between interview and observation data to ensure triangulation. Data saturation was reached when no new themes emerged from the interviews, which occurred after the 20th interview. The remaining interviews confirmed the identified themes, ensuring the comprehensiveness of the data. For child observation data, it was understood that saturation would be reached once the researchers gleaned insights from the entire sample.

3.4. Interview protocol

In the study's interview protocol, fathers' perceptions of their children's play are explored across various modules with targeted questions. "Child Routines and Characteristics" module consisted of questions asking fathers to describe their child's typical day, play activities, and related challenges. "Play and Interaction" module consisted of questions about recent play sessions, preferred toys or objects, favorite playmates, and family or neighborhood involvement in play. "Child's Behavior and Discipline in Play" module explored fathers' responses to challenging behavior and discipline styles during play. In "Experiences with HPL" module, fathers described their children's play activities within HPL and any behavioral changes or preferences since joining. Each module seeks to understand different facets of children's play from the fathers' perspective.

3.5. Researcher positionality

The following positionality statement reflects the collective standpoint of the research team. This study was conducted by a team of six authors with professional backgrounds in early childhood development, evaluation, and refugee studies and was led by Bangladeshi- and U.S.-based researchers. Data collection in the camps was conducted by trained local enumerators from Chittagong who were fluent in Rohingya dialects and familiar with camp dynamics. Their insider knowledge enabled access and rapport with families, though limited mobility within the camps necessitated rapid, focused observation and interview periods. As authors, we acknowledge our backgrounds as academics and practitioners and, for some, as outsiders to the Rohingya community, which may have influenced how questions were posed, which themes were prioritized, and how findings were interpreted.

Of the six authors, four were directly involved in qualitative data analysis and/or interpretation of interview data from fathers. Author 1 identifies as a woman and is not a parent and led the conceptualization of the study, conducted the analysis, and led the manuscript writing.

Author 2 identifies as a woman and is not a parent and was involved in data collection, trained the enumerators, conducted field visits to support data quality, and contributed to analysis, translation, and interpretation of the interview data. Author 3 identifies as a woman and is not a parent and contributed to selected components of data analysis and writing. Author 4 identifies as a man and is not a parent and contributed to planning the data collection and to the interpretation of the findings. The authors' gender and parental status shaped their reflexive engagement with the data, particularly in interpreting fathers' narratives surrounding play, caregiving, and perceptions of child safety.

The remaining two authors were not involved in interview-based data analysis. Author 5 identifies as a woman and is a parent and contributed to qualitative data collection and broader interpretation of qualitative findings. Author 6 identifies as a woman and is a parent and contributed to the planning, analysis, writing, and interpretation of the rapid ethnographic data.

Across the research team, attention to gender and parental status informed ongoing reflexive discussion. By explicitly articulating researcher positionality, we aim to enhance transparency and acknowledge how these factors may have shaped the interpretation of fathers' perspectives on play.

3.6. Ethical considerations

Ethical approval for the study was obtained from the Institutional Review Board at the X (anonymized) University. Informed consent was secured from all participating fathers, with assurances of confidentiality and the right to withdraw at any time without consequences.

4. Results

Six themes emerged from the data, detailing fathers' experiences and perceptions regarding their children's play and safety in the refugee camps. Themes are presented below in order of frequency, beginning with those discussed by the most fathers. Table 1 summarizes the themes and the number of fathers mentioning each.

A rapid ethnographic assessment provided additional contextual observation of children's play environments. Table 2 summarizes these contextual themes (song/rhyme in play; mixed-age group play; flexible use of space; imaginative play in sometimes hazardous contexts).

While the analytic focus is on fathers' perspectives (Table 1), the rapid ethnographic assessment (Table 2) offers contextual evidence that supports and deepens these themes; brief observation excerpts are integrated below where relevant. Sub-themes are presented as codes that further elaborate each theme.

1) Fathers' Observations of Children's Play (All fathers, n=25)

Fathers observe their children creatively using household items to make toys and engage in mixed-age peer play, where older children often guide and scaffold activities for younger ones. All fathers reported specific knowledge of what their children play with and with whom they engage during play.

Table 1
Thematic categories emerging from fathers' perspectives on play.

Themes	Number of fathers
1. Fathers' Observations of Children's Play	All fathers (25)
2. Concerns About Physical Safety and Play-Related Injuries	All fathers (25)
3. Role of play in children's emotions and behavior	Majority of the fathers (21)
4. Fathers' increased time with children	Majority of the fathers (18)
5. Imagination and pretend-play among children	Majority of the fathers (16)
6. Perception of HPL as a place to play and learn	More than half of the fathers (13)

Table 2
Thematic categories emerging from rapid ethnographic assessment.

Themes	Description
1. Play through song and rhyme	Children often hum, sing, and sway while engaged in other activities. This was observed in both individual and group play.
2. Self-organized group play across ages	Children frequently play in mixed-age groups made up of siblings, extended family, and other children in the community. Even when age differences are wide, younger children join in the same activities as older peers.
3. Flexible use of space	While children were most often observed playing in their homes, many activities extended across multiple households and into public spaces.
4. Imaginative play in hazardous contexts	Rohingya children were seen developing their own games and toys with objects readily available to them in the absence of 'store-bought' toys and games. Rohingya children often used objects they found around them in play settings, including tubing and sand. Nevertheless, children were also seen playing in unsuitable areas (e.g. near open sewage) or playing with objects that could be dangerous (e.g. sharp/broken objects or fire).

4.1. Sub-theme 1a: What children play with

All fathers in the study were able to provide precise answers about the items that their children play with and were able to share examples of scenarios where these items were utilized. One father explained that his child creates objects to play with out of household items such as sticks and rubber: "he plays with kites and makes houses with papers and cars with bamboo sticks. Sometimes he makes bullets with rubber and sticks. He often plays football with other kids" (Father, 25-year-old; boy child, 5-year-old), displaying to researchers that creative engagement with play materials was a part of the play process.

Rohingya children play with toys and objects they find close to them. More than half of the fathers explained that children use items in their immediate surroundings, such as items from the kitchen, where a father shared that his daughter "plays with wastage of raw vegetables from the kitchen with her elder sister" (Father, 25-year-old, girl child, 2-year-old).

Ethnographic observations also showed children were seen playing with plastic bottles, sand, sticks, feathers, and yarn—e.g., a child shaking an empty drink bottle to make sound; another rolling and rewinding a yarn cone with focused attention.

Arif (4-year-old boy child) is murmuring to himself as he looks down at a roll of yarn on a black plastic cone that he is holding. The length of yarn left is very little, almost all the black cone is exposed. He looks for the end of the yarn by tracing the clump with his fingers. He finds the end and picks it up. He then throws the cone on the ground and the cone rolls down and the yarn is loosened. He walks towards the cone and picks it up. He starts wrapping the yarn around the cone again while sticking his tongue out slightly.

4.2. Sub-theme 1b: Who children play with

All Rohingya fathers in the interviews were inclined to notice who their children were engaging with on most occasions. More than half of the fathers reported that Rohingya parents want to ensure their children play within their own blocks, which are the smallest units of neighborhood within the Rohingya camps with twenty-five households on average per block (European Council of Refugees and Exiles, 2019). Most fathers in the study reported that children play with their siblings or cousins and other young children who live nearby: "my son usually plays with her younger brother. Sometimes, he plays with some children who live nearby, especially one child named Abbul" (Father, 25-year-old; boy child, 5-year-old). One father also mentioned playing with the child: "he plays mostly with his younger brother. Sometimes he plays

with his mother and me” (Father, 27-year-old; boy child, 3-year-old). Most fathers reported that children love to play by running, jumping, and clapping with other children of similar ages as well as those slightly older than them.

Ethnographic observations also showed mixed-age groups self-organized and older children often scaffolded younger peers’ play.

Raihan (5-year-old boy child) was sitting with a long bamboo stick in his hands. Ashraf (4-year-old boy child) was sitting beside him. Both were facing the health post from the other side of the road. Raihan stood up holding the stick. Ashraf was holding an old pencil bag. He gave Raihan the pencil bag. Raihan started walking away with the bag and the stick. He was walking balancing the stick in between his neck and head. He stopped by the fence and looked downside.....There was a gathering of a few people at the slope of the hill where he was heading. They were all talking in loud voices. Raihan got excited seeing something there and ran faster. A few seconds later, he climbed up the hill laughing and shouting in their language. He was still holding the stick. Climbing up, he stood beside four other children standing near the fence.

In some of the accounts of mixed-age peer group play, the older children are directing or scaffolding the different play related activities, in ways that the Western literature usually describes the role of an adult:

The premises: in a house where a mat was spread on the ground. There is a setup of kitchen toys on the mat which includes 5 small plates, one broken fork, one half coconut shell, one bottle cork and a big plastic box. Fatema (3-year-old girl child) was sitting on the mat in the premises with her other friends. Yasmin (5-year-old girl child) said to everyone, “Done! Let’s move.” They all stood up, took different things of the arrangement in their hands.

2) Concerns About Physical Safety and Play-Related Injuries (All fathers, n=25)

A recurring theme from interviews was that fathers were concerned about the safety of their children in more than one way. Within this broader theme, three sub-themes emerged from the coding process: fear of kidnappers, fear of road accidents, and concerns about physical harm during play-fights.

4.3. Sub-theme 2a: Fear of kidnappers or getting lost in large crowds

Some of the fathers expressed serious concerns over the number of people from local and international organizations who visited the camp on a regular basis, worrying that their children might be kidnapped or lost in large crowds of people. One father mentioned that he was “more worried about my (the father’s) children here because this area is overcrowded, and children easily get lost in the crowd” (Father, 48-year-old; girl child, 4-year-old), while another shared, “my short-term worry is that my child might get lost – she is still very young (Father, 25-year-old; girl, 3-year-old). Others mentioned fears of kidnapping including one father who expressed concerns when children “play on the streets—there is always a chance of being kidnapped” (Father, 25-year-old; girl child, 4-year-old). Another shared similar worries: “I worry for my child going outside of the home because anything can happen—a road accident might happen, or she may get kidnapped” (Father, 31-year-old; girl child, 3 year 6-month-old).

In 2019, UNHCR and its partners reported more than 170 cases of missing persons, abductions, and kidnappings in the refugee camps of Cox’s Bazar (Donovan, 2019). This further informs our understanding of why fathers are concerned with their young children playing outdoors and the reason behind their fear of kidnappers in the camp environment.

4.4. Sub-theme-2b: Fear of road accidents

As aid workers, development professionals, and volunteers visit the camps daily, some areas can get busy and unsafe for children at play. All the fathers interviewed were worried about their children’s safety due to frequent road accidents in the camps by cars and auto rickshaws, or even the *tuk-tuk* (local vehicles). Some children like to play by the alley or

roadside. Considering the poorly constructed roads in the camps, fathers worry that their children may get into an accident. A father explained, “because children always play on the roads, I fear that any accident can happen at any time” (Father, 25-year-old; girl child 4). Another expressed a similar concern: “I worry if my children may get hurt by slipping off” (Father, 27-year-old; boy child, 3-year-old).

4.5. Sub-theme 2c: Fear of physical harm during play-fights

Fathers worry about their children getting injured during play-fights due to the lack of safe play spaces in the camp. Close to half of the fathers observed children were getting into fights with each other due to the lack of safe play spaces, which led to children getting hurt. One father mentioned, “my son gets into quarrels often and fights with other children. One time he bruised his arms. After that we had to interfere – otherwise my son would have gotten [badly] hurt” (Father, 45-year-old; boy child, 3-year-old). Another one reported, “I worry about my children the most. When I go to work, I am always worried about their safety and well-being whether they are getting involved in any fights with other children....” (Father, 30-year-old; boy child, 3-year-old).

Ethnographic observations reinforced these accounts. Children were frequently seen engaging in imaginative play with found materials—such as bottles, tubing, and sticks—but often in unsafe environments. For instance, children played near open sewage, along busy pathways, and with sharp or broken objects. These observations underscore fathers’ anxieties, showing how children’s resourcefulness in creating games is intertwined with the physical risks of camp life. Fathers’ vigilance around safety must be read in light of both precarious camp conditions and Rohingya cultural constructions of fatherhood as protector.

Overall, fathers’ fears around physical safety and play related injuries are deeply shaped by the Rohingya camp context, where overcrowding, frequent NGO and visitor presence, and poorly maintained roads create heightened risks. Fathers’ anxieties reflect broader cultural responsibilities to safeguard children in unstable and resource-scarce environments.

3) Role of play in children’s emotions and behavior (Majority, n=21)

Fathers perceive play as crucial for their children’s emotional well-being, noting its calming effects but also facing challenges in limiting playtime. During the interviews, fathers perceived play as integral to the emotions, well-being, and behavior of their children. The majority of the respondents reported that children like to play all the time, and believe that it helps them stay calm, mentioning that children get upset when they are forcibly brought home by interrupting any ongoing play. Play, in this regard, seems to have a calming effect on children’s emotions, while fathers found it challenging to limit children’s playtime. One father explained, “my son gets angry sometimes when I forbid him to play. He wants to play all the time” (Father, 25-year-old; boy, 2-year-old). Another reported:

Every afternoon, my son refuses to come home for his lunch or to take a nap. I call him, his mother calls him, but he wants to play outside, and this is challenging for us (to bring him home by interrupting his play). (Father; 25-year-old; boy child, 2-year-old)

These quotes show that most fathers notice how important play is to their children’s well-being but that it may also be linked to challenges in parenting. In Rohingya culture, fathers take primary responsibility for disciplining children outside the home, reflecting gendered norms around women’s limited mobility.

Ethnographic observations offered further support showing that children were frequently seen humming, singing, and swaying as they played, suggesting that rhythmic expression was part of how they remained absorbed and emotionally regulated during activities. This aligns with fathers’ perceptions that play helps children release energy and maintain calm in the crowded camp setting.

4) Fathers increased time with children (Majority, n=18)

Fathers in refugee camps, lacking formal employment, often spend more time with their children, engaging in activities like walking, playing, or visiting local shops.

Away from home in a refugee camp setting with limited resources, the majority of the fathers often found themselves in difficult situations with no access to formal employment, resulting in their families depending on rations and support from humanitarian organizations/host country government assistance. These circumstances resulted in stressful situations for fathers as they are primarily responsible for household finances. One of the fathers reported, “Back in Myanmar, I have my own farmland and livestock. I had to leave everything behind when Myanmar army attacked us. Here in Bangladesh, we may sleep soundly, but I have worries about money. I have no employment” (Father, 31-year-old; girl child, 3.5-year-old).

Some of the fathers managed to find temporary employment as volunteers or day-laborers. However, most fathers in our study spent most of their time at home or in *bazaar* (local market) around the neighborhood. As a result, these fathers were spending more time with their children in general. The majority of the Rohingya fathers also acknowledged spending time participating in different outdoor activities with their children. One father mentioned “I take him to the shops and buy him snacks” (30-year-old; boy child, 3-year-old) and another said, “When I find him (the child) unmanageable, I often take him out for a stroll and buy him fried chips” (Father 35-year-old; boy 2-year-old). Another father reported, “my daughter loves to go outside. Whenever I come home, she always insists that I take her out for a short walk” (23-year-old, girl child 2-year-old).

5) Imagination and pretend-play among children (Majority, n=16)

Fathers report children participating in pretend-play, such as mimicking adult roles or engaging in symbolic games using locally available materials. Majority of the fathers reported that children like to participate in ‘pretend-play’, which is also known as symbolic play, imaginative play, dramatic play, or make-believe (Clark et al., 1989). Almost all fathers reported their children engaged in pretend play in some capacity, sharing that they sometimes acted like characters from a story or someone from a specific profession. During the interviews, fathers seemed to encourage their children to engage in pretend play, such as playing *ghor ghor* (imaginative household), where children act like their own parents, pretending to cook food. Some fathers shared their observations, mentioning “he runs around with other kids and plays with whatever he can get, even with polythene (plastic) bags. He pretends to act like us (the parents) and play *ghor ghor*. Sometimes, he acts like a police officer and chases other kids” (Father, 25-year-old; boy child 5-year-old) and “I saw my daughter playing *ghor ghor* and she would make cakes with mud. And then she will pretend to feed her younger sister” (Father, 35-year-old; girl child 3-year-old).

In addition to playing *ghor ghor*, most of the fathers described other types of play that their children engaged in, such as *saun hodda*, which roughly translates to ‘kitchenware toys’ which could be bought or made with locally available materials such as coconut shells or sticks. They also described *bezal-tiya* or *atu-tiya* which usually involved children using fake money made of leaves or paper while pretending to go to the *bazaar* (local market).

Ethnographic data supported these accounts, showing that children often sang or hummed while absorbed in play activities. These rhythmic expressions, sometimes accompanied by swaying, were observed in both individual and group settings, reinforcing fathers’ descriptions of imaginative and expressive forms of play. Ethnographic observations also showed children collaboratively enacted domestic and market scripts using repurposed materials (e.g., hanging a mat as a curtain to “re-set” the play space).

Ansar (7-year-old boy child) punched softly on the left side of her chest and said, “Sit!”. Rakiba was still staring at what Kolima was doing with the spoon and the pan on the stove. Suddenly Ansar picked a small stick up and threw it out of their playing zone. Mostafa (4-year-old boy

child) was cleaning up a plate. Rakiba stood up and started wandering around. Ansar asked Yasir to stand up and leave. As soon as Yasir stood up and moved away, Ansar picked the mat up from the ground and hung it with a knob stick so that it can be used as a curtain.

Pretend play like *ghor ghor* reflects children’s absorption of cultural scripts of domestic life, showing how cultural knowledge is reproduced through play.

6) Perception of HPL as a place to play and learn (More than half, n=13)

Fathers view HPLs as spaces where children can play and learn basic skills but do not recognize them as places for emotional healing. According to some of the fathers interviewed, play is an important part of the HPLs in which their children were enrolled. Almost half of the fathers perceived the main goal of these HPLs, known as *kela khanas* in the Rohingya language, meaning a place to play, to provide space for children to play with other children. Fathers seemed familiar with the main activities of the HPLs where children engage in basic learning, such as reading, writing, counting, and Burmese/Arabic language learning, as well as eating, playing games, or singing songs. A father shared, “I saw her sometimes studying, sometimes playing, and sometimes clapping in different ways” (Father, 31-year-old; girl child, 3.5-year-old) and “she loves to go to HPL because she can play. She is also learning Burmese alphabets, and a few poems with other kids” (Father, 23-year-old; girl, 2-year-old). Another reported:

My son learns to draw flowers with the color pencils he received from HPL. He also loves to eat the biscuits given to him at HPL. Previously, he couldn’t hold a pen but now he can write and draw. He plays all the time. He also recites the poems that he learnt there at home now. (Father, 25-year-old, boy child, 5-year-old)

Half of the fathers in our interviews seem to view HPLs as sites for learning and play. Despite not making an explicit connection between play and learning, fathers acknowledged that their children engaged in learning alphabets and poems and playing at HPLs. However, the relationship between the development of socio-emotional skills and healing in these designated play spaces were not mentioned by any parent during the interviews. These findings are reflected in the following excerpts. A father said, “my daughter learned how to recite many poems and play with different things at the HPL” (Father, 40-year-old; girl child, 3-year-old). Another father explained, “I heard children are studying Burmese language, and poems at the *khela khana*; all I see is him playing, always” (Father, 33-year-old; 4-year-old). One of them reported, “previously, my son didn’t know how to play, build different things, and recite a poem. Now, he is more friendly. He made friends and learned basic numeracy” (Father, 34-year-old; boy child, 4-year-old).

Almost half of the fathers mentioned that they were less involved in HPLs compared to the mothers, who were reported as the ones primarily facilitating children’s interactions with HPL.

Apart from these major worries, most fathers expressed helplessness in protecting their children from injury and accidents due to poverty and lack of a stable livelihood in the camp. They worried about financial challenges and the restrictions they faced in meeting the daily needs of their children. A father mentioned, “inside the camp, it’s difficult to earn money, and as a father, I feel stranded. Now that they are very young, we are managing anyhow, but what will happen when they are old? I worry a lot for our future” (Father, 33-year-old; boy child, 4-year-old). Several fathers struggled to provide their children with clothes and blankets during winter.

5. Discussion

This study offers the first analysis, to our knowledge, of fathers’ perceptions of young children’s play and their involvement in play among the Rohingya. To anchor the discussion, we return to our central research question: How do fathers perceive their time with children, particularly regarding play, in unstructured (home and surrounding areas) and structured (HPL) settings in the Rohingya camps in Cox’s

Bazar, Bangladesh? Our findings indicate that fathers' perceptions and involvement were shaped by the unique conditions of displacement, shifting gendered roles, and everyday camp dynamics across both types of play settings.

Displacement increased fathers' time with children and, given their greater mobility than mothers, made them especially attentive to outdoor play and its dangers. Displacement disrupted traditional provider roles and, unlike studies of South Asian fathers as primarily breadwinners (Jesmin & Seward, 2011), repositioned Rohingya fathers—often unemployed or in sporadic informal work—as consistent caregivers with increased time to closely observe their children's play. This shift echoes global evidence on how father involvement supports early literacy (Roopnarine & Yildirim, 2019), numeracy (Frongillo et al., 2017), and socio-emotional growth (McWayne et al., 2013). In the Rohingya context, these roles are further shaped by cultural constructions of fatherhood as protectors and disciplinarians outside the home. Although mothers are central to children's daily care, this study focused on fathers given their distinct mobility and visibility in outdoor play.

Fathers' views are deeply embedded in socio-cultural norms, religious practices, and traditional gender roles, which significantly shape how they understand parenting and early childhood development. In particular, fathers emphasized structured education, such as religious schooling in *madrasas*, over unstructured play—a pattern consistent with South Asian and Muslim-majority contexts where academic preparation often takes precedence (Ball and Khan Wahedi, 2010; Taylor & Boyer, 2020). Yet displacement shifted these dynamics. Fathers increasingly recognized the therapeutic and developmental potential of play, noting its role in cultivating creativity, social interaction, and emotional healing. This adaptation parallels research in Nigeria and South Africa, where communities initially resisted play-based learning but later embraced its developmental benefits (Ogunyemi & Henning, 2020). In the Rohingya camps, fathers appeared more open to this shift, observing clear benefits for their children.

Fathers' accounts of pretend play, particularly *ghor ghor*, where children mimic domestic life, demonstrate how cultural scripts are reproduced and reinterpreted through play. Such practices highlight both the specificity of Rohingya family roles and the universality of play themes across societies (Gaskins & Paradise, 2010). Programs like HPLs that build on *kabbiyas* (folk rhymes) and *kissas* (stories) illustrate how culturally resonant approaches increase both acceptance and developmental impact (Mariam et al., 2021; Taylor & Boyer, 2020).

Resourcefulness was another recurrent theme. Fathers described children fashioning toys from vegetable scraps, bottles, or plastic bags—an adaptation mirrored in ethnographic observations. This resourcefulness reflects both scarcity and cultural adaptability. These findings align with prior research on the universality of pretend play (Gaskins & Paradise, 2010; Leyva & Skorb, 2017) and risky play in constrained settings (Sandseter et al., 2021; Ogunyemi & Henning, 2020). Observational data corroborated fathers' accounts, showing children's imaginative activities closely mirrored their immediate environments and parental behaviors, underscoring play's resilience even in adverse conditions (Lester & Russell, 2010; Mariam et al., 2019).

Peer dynamics provided important scaffolding. Half of the fathers reported children primarily playing in local blocks, often in mixed-age groups. Ethnographic data showed older children organizing, directing, and scaffolding younger peers' play—roles that mirror adult facilitation in WEIRD contexts but are assumed by peers in the camps. Similar patterns have been documented in Cameroon (Nsamenang, 2010) and Morocco (García-Sánchez, 2016), where mixed-age play fosters social competence and cooperation. In the absence of structured, adult-supervised opportunities, these peer groups function as informal learning spaces transmitting discipline, negotiation, and caregiving norms.

Fathers also played a role in extending children's socialization beyond the home. In both Rohingya and Bangladeshi cultures, gendered roles position fathers as facilitators of external interactions (Ball and

Khan Wahedi, 2010). *Bazaar* trips, for instance, exposed children to social exchanges between fathers and host community members, offering lessons in negotiation and participation. Such experiences resonate with literature on play-based and observational learning (Taylor & Boyer, 2020; Ogunyemi & Henning, 2020), while also underscoring the importance of everyday interactions in children's broader integration into host communities.

Safety emerged as a central theme. In the camp context, fathers' greater mobility and outdoor presence made them especially attentive to children's exposure to risks such as kidnapping, road accidents, and unsafe play environments. These concerns must be read against both precarious camp conditions and cultural constructions of fatherhood as protector. Vigilance over children's safety becomes a central expression of fatherhood. Such anxieties echo global literature on unsafe play environments (Ogunyemi & Henning, 2020) and demonstrate how insecurity reshapes parenting in displacement contexts.

These concerns also highlight intervention opportunities. Community-based playgroups led by trained facilitators, similar to Mali's Mama Yeleen initiative (Britto et al., 2021), could provide structured, supervised spaces within camps. Establishing designated play areas—framed as both physically and emotionally safe—would not only address fathers' anxieties but also build community cohesion. Such interventions align with global evidence that supervised, culturally grounded play improves developmental outcomes and parental engagement (Schottelkorb et al., 2012; Kwon & Lee, 2018).

The study's limitations reflect its context-specific design. Findings are drawn from fathers in Rohingya refugee camps, where displacement increased their home presence and mothers' mobility was highly restricted. While this focus aligned with the study's aims, it excluded mothers' perspectives, which could provide important complementary insights. Future research should incorporate both parents to capture a fuller picture of children's play. Finally, because our analysis emphasizes outdoor play in overcrowded camps, the findings may not generalize to other settings with different spatial and social dynamics.

6. Conclusion and implications for practice

This study provides new insights into how Rohingya fathers perceive and support children's play in the refugee camps of Bangladesh. Displacement has reshaped paternal roles, giving fathers more time with children and positioning them as protectors, observers, and facilitators of outdoor play.

For practice, three implications stand out. First, ECD programs can leverage fathers' increased time at home by recruiting father volunteers to engage peers and link *kela* (play) with *shikhon* (learning), as shown by research in areas such as cognitive growth (Sethna et al. 2017), early literacy (Roopnarine & Yildirim, 2019), numeracy (Frongill et al., 2017), and social development (McWayne, et al., 2013). Second, naturally occurring mixed-age peer groups can be leveraged as informal learning spaces, where younger children acquire skills and older children practice leadership. Third, fathers' widespread safety concerns highlight the need for designated, supervised play areas that address both physical risks and cultural expectations of fatherhood as protector. Furthermore, framing *kela khanas* as safe physical and emotional spaces, where children learn and play, may also be helpful to increase fathers' support for HPLs.

More broadly, these findings underscore the value of culturally responsive approaches. Programs that center local play traditions—such as rhymes, stories, and domestic role play—alongside safe play environments are likely to gain fathers' support and strengthen early development outcomes. Ultimately, engaging fathers in play-based learning is not only a child development strategy but also a pathway toward community resilience in contexts of forced displacement.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Fatima Tuz Zahra: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Supervision, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Shikhty Sunny:** Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Conceptualization. **Sneha Bolisetty:** Writing – original draft. **Hirokazu Yoshikawa:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Resources, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Conceptualization. **Yes-him Iqbal:** Writing – review & editing, Data curation. **Sharon Kim:** Writing – original draft.

Declaration of competing interest

We have no conflicts of interest to disclose.

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Data availability

The data that has been used is confidential.

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